Medusa's Tale

By Carol S. Lashof

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *In Greek mythology, the stories of Medusa are often contradictory. Was she a victim or a villain? Was she always ugly or once beautiful?*

ACTOR: *One story reports Medusa's beauty was so stunning that many men courted her, but she became a priestess in Athena's temple.*

ACTRESS: *Her golden hair and her beauty attracted the lustful eyes of the sea god, Poseidon.*

ACTOR: *They consummated their relationship in Athena's temple, a terrible violation of a sacred place.*

ACTRESS: *Stories differ as to whether he raped Medusa or she enticed him first.*

ACTOR: *Regardless . . . when Athena learned what had happened she flew into a rage and cursed Medusa with snakes for hair and a face that turned those who looked at her to stone.*

ACTRESS: *But this was not enough for Athena:. . . eventually she sent her brother Perseus to bring back the gorgon's head.*

TOGETHER: *This is Medusa's Tale by Carol S. Lashof*

MEDUSA hums a jaunty love song-perhaps "Froggie Went a 'Couriing."

PERSEUS: I am the hero Perseus, son of the great god Zeus.

MEDUSA: And I'm Medusa, cast out by gods and kings. You've come to slay me, I presume? *(Pause.)* Cat got your tongue? You warriors, you're all alike. Look at these fellows: civilized young men, from the very best families, but no appreciation whatsoever for the art of conversation. They do make handsome statues, though, don't they?

PERSEUS: It's true that you turn people to stone just by looking at them? Evil monster, beware ...

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MEDUSA: Do I look like an evil monster? Tell me. I want to know.

PERSEUS: Don't think you can trick me into meeting your eyes. Athena has blessed me with wisdom. She has sent me to carry out her will.

MEDUSA: Athena! If you're her slave, then I'll gladly stop your blood dead in your veins.

PERSEUS: I am not her slave. I am her brother. She is the greatest goddess of them all, sprung fully armed from Zeus's noble brow. And I, too, am a child of the almighty Zeus, lord of the heavens. Who but he could have slipped through the bars of that tower, a hundred feet high, where she was locked up, my mother. ...

MEDUSA: And how did Zeus manage this fancy trick? Did he come as a mosquito and buzz in between the bars of her prison window? Did he impregnate her with a sting?

PERSEUS: Blasphemer! He came as a shower of gold.

MEDUSA: *(Pause. Astonished.)* Are you Danae's child? You can't be. She did have a son, but they were both drowned long ago, she and her baby. I knew Danae. *(Pause.)* We were girls together. She used to braid my hair while I told her stories of distant lands. She was hungry for knowledge. But then her father killed her.

PERSEUS: My mother told me we were rescued from the sea when I was a baby.

MEDUSA: When you get angry, you knit your brows just the way Danae used to do. No! Don't turn away from me. Close your eyes. Let me look at you. You've got your mother's figure-long and slim.

PERSEUS: Don't touch me, hag! I don't believe you knew my mother. She would never have gone near such a monster as you.

MEDUSA: I was no monster, then. I was honored for my beauty. Poseidon himself was in love with me. Do you know what the love of the gods has done for me?

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PERSEUS: Everyone knows you were cursed by the gods for your crimes.

MEDUSA: No one knows! *(Pause.)* If I set you free, will you listen to my story? Will you go home and tell Danae?

PERSEUS: I'll never go home unless I can take your bloody head with me.

MEDUSA: **(***Pause.)* All right. If it has to be that way. Listen closely so you may judge for yourself what the love of the gods is worth. . . . Now we are in Athens. Look there. On the hill. Above the well. Glaring white against the blue horizon. Athena's sanctuary. And there she is. The goddess of justice. Favorite daughter of Zeus. And here comes Poseidon, Earthshaker. Brother of Zeus and Lord of the Ocean.

ATHENA: Honored uncle, what brings you to my blessed city?

POSEIDON: Just passing through.

ATHENA: Flourishing. Thanks to the olive tree, all the citizens of Athens enjoy my bounty.

POSEIDON: And the women and slaves of Athens enjoy a mule's life.

ATHENA: Slaves must drive the mill wheels so their masters may be free to keep the wheels of justice turning. I have given the Athenians the gifts of law and commerce-and they adore me for it.

POSEIDON: They're afraid of Zeus and his thunderbolts, that's all.

ATHENA: You're jealous of the love these mortals bear for me.

POSEIDON: Love! You're far too icy-hearted to know anything about love.

ATHENA: Naturally, I disdain the appetites that drive mere beasts to grunt and thrash. (Two *girls are heard approaching from the distance, chattering and laughing.)*

POSEIDON: Now here comes a truly lovable being. Who's she? The dark one with her

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hair down her back.

ATHENA: Medusa. She's been conducting a faithful pilgrimage to all my temples. She blesses me for protecting her chastity, the wellspring of her freedom.

POSEIDON: Chastity! The emptiest of all the empty virtues. . . . but if she knew the love of a real god ...

ATHENA: She would spurn you. And your brutish love.

POSEIDON: Do you think so? Let me have just half an hour alone with her.

ATHENA: You may have half of all eternity. Nothing you can do could wrest her love from me.

POSEIDON: We'll see. (POSIDON *approaches, whistling a sea song.)* And what's your name?

MEDUSA: Medusa.

POSEIDON: How old are you?

MEDUSA: Seventeen.

POSEIDON: Too old for a mother's caresses.

MEDUSA: I never knew my mother. She died when I was born.

POSEIDON: You're old enough to be a mother yourself.

MEDUSA: I don't want children. That's why I follow Athena.

POSEIDON: Do you know who I am?

MEDUSA: Of course. You're Poseidon. My father works for you.

POSEIDON: Wouldn't you like to bear the child of a god?

MEDUSA: No. Mv friend Danae had a child by Zeus and her father killed her for it. An oracle told him that he'd be killed by his grandson. So he killed the baby and Danae, too, so she wouldn't produce any more sons. He tossed them both in a casket and shoved them out to sea. They must have drowned. Or starved.

POSEIDON: A god would never allow a son of his to come to harm. I could easily pay a visit to my brother Zeus and find out about Danae for you.

MEDUSA: W ould you?

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POSEIDON: For a price. Don't you care to know what's happened to your friend?

MEDUSA: What good would it do? I'm sure she's dead.

POSEIDON: All right, then. Be seeing you, *(Whistling,Poseidon begins to walk away.)*

MEDUSA: Wait! *(Pause. Almost a whisper.]* What is your price?

POSEIDON: To intercede on behalf of your friend? What would you give me?

MEDUSA: My hair. I'll cut off all my hair and give it to you. (*Poseidon laughs.)* Men always beg me for just one lock. They say they will keep it always, it will be their clearest treasure.

POSEIDON: You have a dearer treasure than your shiny hair. Have you given that away?

MEDUSA: I don't know what you mean. You're hurting me. Let me go!

POSEIDON: All I want is a kiss. Hmmm. Don't clench your teeth. Oww! So you bite, do you? Vixen! Oof! And kick, too? That's all right, I like a little spice in my stew. Go ahead. Run to Athena's sanctuary. It's a fine and private place. *(Gasping for breath, MEDUSA scuttles across the stone colonnade. The heavy doors of the temple creak.)*

MEDUSA: In Athena's name. Please. This is holy ground.

POSEIDON: *(Laughing.)* Wherever I am is holy ground.

MEDUSA: Athena! Please! Save me, Athena!

NARRATOR: *POSEIDON laughs. MEDUSAscreams. Then there is silence. Finally, we hear MEDUSAsobbing;* POSEIDON, *whistling, emerges onto the colonnade. The temple doors clang shut, muffling the sound of* MEDUSA's *sobs.*

ATHENA: I didn't count on your brutalizing her within the walls of my own temple. It's an offense against all the gods. There'll be no harmony in the heavens till penance has been done!

POSEIDON: So punish the girl for taking refuge in your sanctuary. Am I to blame because she clung to the feet of your statue while I took her? So, Athena, do you still claim the girl as yours? Such a fine creature. What a pity if

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she'd gone to her grave a virgin. Hush. Here she is now. Ask her if she still adores you. (*MEDUSA approaches, weeping.)* Come, my dear, don't cry. There's no harm done.

MEDUSA: *(Strangling a scream.)* Stay away from me! Athena. Don't let him touch me, please.

POSEIDON: That's right, Brighteyes, hide the girl behind your skirts. But you did nothing while we took our pleasure in the heart of your temple. You stood in the doorway and watched. *(Silence.)*

ATHENA: You should have run away before it was too late. It's foolish pride for a mortal girl to have no fear of gods.

POSEIDON: See, Medusa. Athena will have nothing more to do with you. Come, you'll live with me in my golden palace. [to audience] And if she's a sweet, tender girl and treats me as a god deserves, then I'll give her jewels and fine sons, and I'll make all my minions bow to her

ATHENA: You won't have her, Poseidon. No one will have her. Father Zeus. Thunderer. Give me the power to punish this sacrilege. *(There is a deafening crash of thunder, followed by a moment's silence. Then the air is filled with hissing. MEDUSA cries out in anguish.)* Zeus has struck you with his lightning. The pain will soon subside. But the vipers will remain, a warning to all vain, glorious mortals. Come, look at your reflection. See the penance you have earned.

MEDUSA: Poseidon, help me! Help me rip them out!

POSEIDON: Nothing could be more hideous. In all the wild sea I have never seen creatures so vile.

MEDUSA: Will you turn from me, too, Poseidon? I'll go with you. I'll learn to find pleasure in your touch. I'll bear your sons ...

POSEIDON: You would bear me monsters.

MEDUSA: But look at me! You found me beautiful. See. My eyes are still bright, my lips

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still moist, my skin still smooth as cream. [POSEIDON leaves] Don't leave me!

ATHENA: Do you dare to turn to him, who ruined you, and beg for pity? Every creature on this earth will turn away from you. See those women, hurrying to be home by dark? The story of your infamy will soon be spread among them-and they will learn not to be so unafraid. And any other mortal who lacks the wisdom to turn his back on you or shut his eyes will turn to stone.

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NARRATOR: And so Medusa concludes her story . . . .

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PERSEUS: I never really wanted to come here. Let me go-before you cloud my wits completely.

MEDUSA: Nobody's keeping you, my young hero. *(Pause.)* Give my regards to your mother. *(Pause.)* What's the matter? Can't you bear to leave me? Or have you forgotten something? Oh, yes, my head. You came for my head, didn't you?

PERSEUS: When I was home, the women hissed at my mother on the street and called her names. The boys threw clods of dung at me. Then Athena came to me. She told me I was destined to be a hero. She told me how to find this desolate place. She said you would be asleep. I only had to avoid looking at you-and then I could easily kill you, she said. *(Pause.)* Did you know that she wears your image emblazoned on her armor? Your face is beautiful. The snakes are hideous, but your eyes, your mouth, more beautiful than any woman I've ever seen. Suppose you'd borne Poseidon's son, wouldn't you want him to grow up to be a hero?

MEDUSA: Do you believe me, then?

PERSEUS: I don't know. Athena is my guardian. I must believe in her. She is wise and just. She would not punish someone who was virtuous.

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MEDUSA: She failed me. And she punishes me for having seen her failure.

PERSEUS: I must kill you. Or else I am nothing.

MEDUSA: Yes, I know. But after you have killed me, then what? Will you go home to your mother? Wll you tell her my story?

PERSEUS: Yes. I'll tell her.

MEDUSA: And what will you do with my head?

PERSEUS: I'll put it in this leather pouch.

MEDUSA: And if anyone makes trouble for you, you'll just whip out my head and turn him into a statue

PERSEUS: I don't know. What difference does it make to you?

MEDUSA: I just want to know how the story ends. *(Pause.)* You're doomed to be a hero.

MEDUSA hums a jaunty love song-perhaps "Froggie Went a 'Couriing."

[PERSEUS beheads MEDUSA with one pass of his sword and places her head in a leather pouch]

PERSEUS: [Sadly] Listen! *(Pause.)* In this leather pouch is the severed head of Medusa, the gorgon known throughout Greece to be the most loathsome of creatures. Hideous vipers grow from her scalp. They are still alive and writhing, though she is dead. One glance at them and you would turn to stone. Many men perished trying to slay this monster. Then I came to the barren island where she lived in exile.

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AWARD HISTORY

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